Whiteout

By Jocelyn Beard

INTRODUCTION

Racism is the product of judgment and pride intertwined. The experiences of yesterday determine the judgments of today, and the judgments of today determine the pride of tomorrow. Racism is learned *not invented. Racism breeds from suffering. Those who suffer are racist – those who impose suffering are racist. Rebecca explains her pride, her judgments and her suffering in "Whiteout" by Jocelyn Beard.*

REBECCA: I will not sit in this house. The fact that the soles of my shoes have to touch your floors is bad enough... Let me tell you something about me, Miss Creek. Let me tell you something that might help you to understand me, since that's your job. Let me tell you about my Great-grandmother. My Great-grandmother was a slave, Miss Creek. Her name was Effie. (*beat)* Don't you "oh" me, you...you...Peckerwood piece of white trash! We are *all* descended from slaves, you ignorant girl. My great-grandmother *was* a slave. Her name was Effie. She was kept on several plantations outside of Richmond, on the James River. Seems she wasn't much of a worker, but she was smart. Smart enough to keep herself out of the fields and out of the Boss's bed. Smart enough to head north when the war was over and Negroes were free to finally get paid to be slaves. Great-grandmother Effie made her way first to Philadelphia, where she worked for several years in the household of an umbrella tycoon. Can you imagine making your fortune making umbrellas? That's white luck for you. Anyway, there was smart, clever Great-grandmother

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Effie cooking up a storm for the umbrella tycoon in Philadelphia when, as her own personal luck would have it, one of the umbrella tycoon's houseguests fell in love with her Liquor Pudding...

In the south, Miss Creek, African American cooks labored to concoct countless dishes irresistible to white men... most of them so high in fat that coronary units should be on stand-by whenever they're served. Call it a sweet revenge. Liquor pudding was Effie's specialty, and a rich politician from New York City by the name of Benjamin Morse fell in love with it. He offered Effie three times what the umbrella tycoon was paying her to come and cook for him in New York and she said, "Yes, Boss. That do sound good to me." She was quite lucky. Great-grandmother Effie grew famous in New York for her unusual culinary skills and for her beauty. In fact, Morse's youngest son, Ezekial, had ardently courted Effie since her arrival. She eventually bore him three sons and three times that in scandal.

Fortunately, the younger Morse was a responsible white boy, and he set Effie up in a little house in Cold Spring, right on the Hudson River, where he continued to visit even after his marriage to a Connecticut heiress. My grandfather, Thomas Morse, grew up with his mother and brothers in that little house on the river and they wanted for nothing. Thomas was able to go to college, and then had the audacity to start his own law practice in Poughkeepsie, New York, in 1922. He married the daughter of one of his first clients, a man by the name of Euclid

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Strange who owned an apple orchard deeded to him by a grateful former employer. My grandmother, Tabitha Strange had grown up on that apple orchard, up in the Hudson Highlands. Grandma Tabby bore Effie six beautiful grandchildren: Euclid, Thomas, Nathan, Philip, Marie and my mother, Willa. Uncle Euclid and Nathan went into law with Grandfather, as did my mother. By the time I was born, Morse, Morse and Wooley was one of the biggest firms in the valley. A black law firm. It was a freak of nature. Both my parents were attorneys. I grew up in a small town named Red Hook that was as white as white can be. We were as white as white can be. Our neighbors were white, our friends were white, we spoke like whites, we ate like whites, we *were* white. I went to a private girl's school with a bunch of other white girls and then on to Harvard and Harvard Law. On the day I was graduated I received a rare and unexpected summons from Cold Spring. I was to present myself to Great-grandmother Effie without delay. I'd only met her a handful of times in my life and truth be told, she had always terrified me. But I was young, fancied myself white and had a J.D.L from Harvard in my pocket, so I drove down to Cold Spring as requested. I'd never been to the house, nor had anyone prepared me for it. The "me" that you seem to think you know was last seen standing in that driveway on that hot June day.

From the driveway, you followed a path through thick forsythia and hydrangea trees to a clearing where Effie's house had stood since a Dutch farmer had built it in the early eighteenth century. As I stood

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there, staring the house...or what had become of it...I didn't think of Holland, I thought of Senegal. Effie had used the years to transform that little Dutch colonial into her memory of the hut in which her mother had been born in Senegal. She'd done it all by herself. She'd even replaced the slate roof with sweet-smelling thatch. I must tell you, Miss Creek, that it quite took my breath away. It was like a memory of a dream. I found her in an herb garden on the other side of the house. She was singing...in Senegalese, dressed in a batik robe of the brightest blues I'd ever seen. Her hair was white, and piled on her head in braids. She must have smelled me, standing there behind her, for she stopped singing and slowly turned around. Her face was ancient, but somehow, still beautiful. In fact, the most startling thing about her, I remember, was that she stood erect; as if life and all its burdens had no claim on her. As if she'd never been a slave. She eyed me up and down, and then she did something I never would have expected.

She laughed, oh good lord how she laughed! She took one look at me in my white clothes with my straightened hair and the look of white concern on my face and she just laughed. She walked with a cane that she didn't seem to need, and she poked it at me and said: "Look at you, child. All dressed up and no place to go." Well, I wasted no time informing her that I did in fact have many places to go...but she cut me off with another poke of her cane and said, "You listen to me, girl child. I got no time to be listening to no pretend white girl, so you just listen to me. By this time next year I'll be dead. My bones be crushed and

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ground to paste the earth. Now, I been carrying something...carrying it with me all the way from Virginia, and it's heavy, girl child, too heavy for me to take with me to the grave. I got to give it to someone to carry to the next one...and you're the one who has to take it. You. Only you."

She reached inside her gown, and pulled out a long necklace. I remember her hands...like little brown spiders...running up and down the necklace as they undoubtedly had every day for seventy years. "This is what I got to give to you, girl child," she said, "but I'm going to keep it on just a little while longer while I introduce you to them."

(As she slowly pulls the necklace out of her own dress.) It was long, white pearls held together by black and white strands... *(She holds up the first "pearl," which is actually a human tooth, as Effie.)* "This be Rummy. The Boss man done whipped him dead. Whipped him so bad that the blood spray all over his Nile green frock coat that little Bess done took more'n a month to sew. Rummy die screamin'. *(The next "pearl.* ") This be Old Paw. The Boss Man done whipped him dead. Old Paw my father's brother. Old Paw keep me from the men on the boat over. Old Paw die screamin'. *(The next "pearl.* ") This be Ben. The Boss Man done whipped him dead. Ben and me was in love. I had Ben's baby in me but the Boss Man punched it out. Ben die screamin'. *(The next "pearl.* ") This be Fifi. The Boss Man done whipped her dead. Fifi was my mama. She held me close in the boat over and not even let go on the block. Fifi slap Boss Man when he take my baby. Fifi die screamin'."

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These are the teeth and the hair of my family. This is all I have. This pitiful ossuary. This is all I have to prove who and what I am. I don't have someone's wedding gown, passed down through generations...I don't have corsages, carefully preserved in plastic...I don't have scrapbooks or photos...all I have are these, yanked from the skulls of my forbears... these, and a great recipe for Liquor Pudding. Great-grandmother Effie gave me a powerful gift that day in her garden, Miss Creek; she gave me the gift of a secret identity. She gave me my destiny. On that day I was made a racist, Miss Creek. Just as you have been made a racist. What you need to know...what isn't in my FBI profile, is that my racist agenda is no less savage than yours.

That is why I cannot and why I will not touch a single thing in *this* particular house. Do I make myself clear?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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